



The \$1,000 Vet Bill



How to See It Coming — and Avoid It

\$1,035

average dog
emergency

8 in 10

owners are not
financially ready

39%

had only minutes
to decide

You cannot control every emergency.
You can control how ready you are for one.

A Note to Dog Parents

Nobody plans for this.

It is a normal evening. Your dog is fine. Then suddenly they are not, and you are in a car at 11pm trying to remember where the emergency clinic is.



Coco lying down, chin on paws, calm trusting eyes looking up

That moment is not the time to be figuring out what things cost.

Here is what the research actually says. The average dog emergency runs about \$1,035. More than eight in ten owners are not financially prepared for it. And in one survey, 39 percent of owners had only minutes to make a life-or-death decision about treatment.

Those are not scare numbers. They are planning numbers.

This guide is not here to frighten you into buying anything. It exists because most owners never see these figures until the moment they are standing at a counter being asked to decide. Seeing them early changes what you can do about them.

It covers what emergencies actually cost, how to tell a call-the-vet-now situation from a wait-and-watch one, and the five expensive emergencies that are largely preventable.

I put it together after a scare with Coco. I did not know any of this beforehand. I do now, and I would rather you did too.

BY THE END OF THIS GUIDE YOU WILL HAVE

Real cost ranges for common emergencies. A triage table you can check in seconds. Your vet and emergency numbers written down where you can find them.

ONE THING BEFORE YOU START

This guide is general information, not veterinary advice. It cannot diagnose your dog. If something feels wrong, call your vet. That call is always the right move.

How Prepared Are You, Really?

Tick every box that is true today. Be honest. Nobody is scoring this but you.



Coco sitting upright, alert and attentive,
small clipboard doodle beside her

- ☐ I know the name and number of my regular vet without looking it up.
- ☐ I know where the nearest 24 hour emergency vet is.
- ☐ I could cover a \$1,000 vet bill this week without borrowing.
- ☐ I have pet insurance, or savings set aside specifically for my dog.
- ☐ I know which human foods are toxic to dogs.
- ☐ I have checked my home for things my dog could swallow.
- ☐ I know which symptoms mean go now versus wait and watch.
- ☐ I have the ASPCA poison control number saved in my phone.

YOUR SCORE

0-3

Worth some prep

You are in the same position most owners are. This guide is built exactly for this.

4-6

Partly covered

You have some of it handled. The gaps are usually the expensive ones.

7-8

Well prepared

You are ahead of most owners. Use this to fill the last gaps and check your numbers.

CONTEXT FOR THAT THIRD QUESTION

In a 2026 survey, 38 percent of owners said they could not cover an emergency vet visit without taking on debt, and only 10 percent had savings set aside specifically for their pet. If you ticked that box, you are in the minority.

1

What Emergencies Cost

The numbers most owners never see until it is urgent.

These are typical ranges, not quotes. Cost varies enormously by city, clinic and how severe the case is. The point is not the exact figure. It is the order of magnitude.

EMERGENCY TYPE	TYPICAL RANGE
Toxin ingestion or poisoning	\$300 – \$3,000+
Foreign object removal surgery	\$1,500 – \$5,000
Bloat (GDV) — life threatening	\$2,000 – \$7,500
Breathing emergency	\$500 – \$3,000
Broken bone or fracture	\$1,000 – \$5,000
Seizure treatment	\$500 – \$2,000
Heat stroke	\$500 – \$2,500
Emergency exam and diagnostics alone	\$150 – \$500

WHY THIS MATTERS MORE THAN IT USED TO

Veterinary costs have risen more than 60 percent since 2014, far outpacing general inflation. One 2026 report put the increase at around 15 percent in that year alone. The bill your neighbour paid three years ago is not the bill you will pay.

Sources: Wheat Ridge Animal Hospital survey via Forbes, June 2026 · Rover 2026 Cost of Dog Parenthood Report · BLS via PBS

MINI GAME

Match the cost

Draw a line from each emergency to its typical range. Check your answers against the table above.

EMERGENCY

TYPICAL RANGE

Bloat (GDV)

\$300 to \$3,000+

Emergency exam only

\$2,000 to \$7,500

Toxin ingestion

\$150 to \$500

Foreign object surgery

\$1,500 to \$5,000

THE WIDER PICTURE

It is not just the size of the bill. It is who is able to absorb it.

38%

could not cover an emergency without taking on debt

Rover 2026

10%

have savings set aside specifically for their pet

Rover 2026

45%

have skipped or delayed vet care because of cost

2026 survey

67%

have faced a surprise bill between \$500 and \$3,000

U.S. News 2026

34%

of owners currently carry pet insurance

U.S. News 2026

83%

say their pet costs went up in the past year

Rover 2026

THE HONEST READ ON THOSE NUMBERS

Most owners are not careless, they are unprepared. Cost is the most cited reason people go without insurance and the most cited reason people delay care. Knowing the numbers early is what gives you options later.



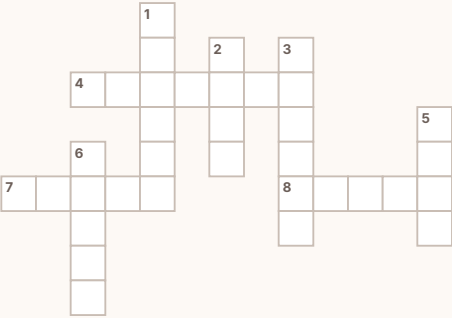
ILLUSTRATION

Coco with a small piggy bank and a calendar doodle, planning-ahead vibe

What to take from this section

You do not need to solve the whole thing tonight. Knowing the ranges, having the numbers written down, and closing the preventable gaps covers most of the risk.

CROSSWORD



Eight words from this guide

ACROSS

- 4. Convulsions, call now
- 7. Swollen belly plus retching
- 8. Poison control line

DOWN

- 1. Two thirds of dogs carry too much
- 2. Pale or blue means call
- 3. Affects most dogs over three
- 5. Flat faced dogs at four times risk
- 6. Grapes, chocolate, xylitol

Five Mistakes That Make Emergencies Cost More

None of these are about being a bad owner. They are about not having thought it through in advance, which is the entire point of this guide.

1

Waiting to see if it resolves on its own

Reasonable instinct, and often correct. But for a handful of conditions like bloat, breathing distress and poisoning, the window is measured in minutes, not hours.

Try instead: Learn the short list on the next page. For everything on it, the calculation changes.

2

Not knowing where the 24 hour clinic is

Your regular vet is likely closed at the exact moment you need one. Searching for a clinic while your dog is in distress costs time you may not have.

Try instead: Look it up now, while nothing is wrong. Write it on page 12.

3

Assuming the first quote is the whole bill

The initial exam is often quoted separately from diagnostics, treatment and overnight stays. Owners are frequently surprised by the gap.

Try instead: Ask directly: what is the estimated total range, including diagnostics and overnight?

4

Skiping the routine things that prevent the expensive things

Dental cleanings, weight management and hazard-proofing feel optional. They are the cheapest preventive spending available.

Try instead: Section 3 covers the five that matter most.

5

Never saying the number out loud

Plenty of owners have no idea what they could actually afford until they are asked. That is a hard moment to work it out.

Try instead: Decide your rough ceiling in advance. It is not cold. It is kinder to everyone, including your dog.

2

Call Now, or Safe to Watch

The most useful page in this guide. Read it before you need it.

HOW TO USE THIS

The left column is not a diagnosis. It lists situations where waiting carries real risk. If your dog matches anything on the left, call. If they match the right and nothing changes, you can reasonably monitor.

CALL NOW

- Struggling to breathe, gasping
- Collapse, or cannot stand up
- Seizure or convulsions
- Known or suspected poisoning
- Vomiting repeatedly, cannot keep water down
- Gums pale, white, blue or grey
- Belly swollen, hard or painful
- Unproductive retching (possible bloat)
- Eye injury or sudden vision loss
- Suspected broken bone
- Unconscious or unresponsive
- Bleeding that will not stop

SAFE TO MONITOR

- Occasional soft stool, no blood
- Mild limp, still bearing weight
- Vomited once, eating normally
- Small surface scrape or cut
- Mild ear scratching
- A little tired after a long walk
- Eating grass occasionally
- Coughing once or twice
- Skipped one meal, otherwise normal
- Sneezing with no discharge
- Mild seasonal itching
- Slightly reduced appetite for a day

WHEN IN DOUBT, CALL

A phone call to your vet or an emergency clinic costs nothing. Every clinic would rather field a question that turns out to be nothing than see a dog that waited too long.

TRIAGE DRILL

Circle your answer

1 Gums have gone pale and your dog seems weak

NOW

WATCH

2 Ate grass on a walk, otherwise bright and eating

NOW

WATCH

3 Retching repeatedly with a hard, swollen belly

NOW

WATCH

Answer key on page 15.

What This Looks Like

In Real Life

Three situations, and how the table applies. Names and dogs are illustrative.

MILO — 4 year old Beagle

Ate something in the garden and vomited once. Bright, alert, drinking water, no other symptoms.

MONITOR

One vomit with a normal, energetic dog sits on the right hand column. Withhold food for a few hours, keep water available, and call in normal hours if it repeats or anything else changes.

BELLA — 7 year old Labrador

Pacing, unsettled, belly looks swollen, retching but nothing comes up.

CALL NOW

This combination of unproductive retching plus a distended abdomen is the classic presentation of bloat, which can become life threatening within hours. This is a straight left column situation.

COCO — 3 year old French Bulldog

Came in from a warm walk breathing harder than usual, noisy, will not settle.

CALL NOW

Flat faced breeds overheat far faster than other dogs. Research from the RVC found flat faced breeds are around four times more likely to suffer heat related illness. Breathing distress in a brachycephalic dog is never a wait and see.

THE PATTERN

Notice what decides it. Not the symptom on its own, but the symptom plus the dog plus the context. A single vomit means one thing in a bright Labrador and another in a lethargic puppy.

WORD SEARCH

Six things worth remembering

Z	Q	B	L	O	A	T	C	Y
F	E	G	E	X	N	P	O	W
Q	W	U	R	W	I	R	W	E
W	G	M	U	Z	X	E	Y	D
N	N	S	Z	A	O	J	E	W
V	C	C	I	M	T	N	V	H
Z	Q	R	E	G	T	O	L	E
M	Y	R	S	A	V	Q	N	A
O	W	A	L	X	U	O	J	T

FIND THESE

BLOAT

TOXIN

DENTAL

GUMS

SEIZURE

HEAT

3

The Preventable Five

The expensive emergencies you can actually do something about.



Coco in a tidy living room, hazards tucked away, safe-home banner composition

1

Toxin ingestion

ASPCA handled over 376,000 exposure cases in 2025

Over the counter medications were the single largest category at around 17 percent. Grapes and raisins alone accounted for more than 9,000 cases.

Do this: Keep medication, grapes, raisins, xylitol, chocolate and onions fully out of reach. Check which houseplants you own. Several common ones are toxic.

2

Swallowed objects

Surgery commonly runs \$1,500 to \$5,000

Socks, corn cobs, string, small toys and bones are the usual culprits. If an object perforates the intestine it becomes life threatening quickly.

Do this: Do not leave socks, string or small toys within reach unsupervised. Frenchies and terriers are particularly determined chewers.

3

Dental disease

Affects 80 to 90 percent of dogs over the age of three

It is the most common disease in dogs, and most owners do not notice until it is advanced because dogs conceal dental pain well. Untreated, it can affect the heart and kidneys.

Do this: Brush three times a week as a minimum. A professional cleaning at \$400 to \$1,200 is considerably cheaper than extraction surgery later.

THE PREVENTABLE FIVE — continued

4

Weight related illness

Around 65 percent of dogs are overweight or obese

Excess weight drives joint disease, diabetes and breathing problems, and shortens life expectancy. One study found roughly a third of owners judged an overweight dog to be a normal weight.

Do this: Measure meals rather than eyeballing them. Keep treats to about 10 percent of daily intake. Ask your vet for an honest body condition score.

5

Heat injury

Flat faced breeds are around four times more at risk

Research from the Royal Veterinary College covering hundreds of thousands of dogs found brachycephalic breeds are far more likely to suffer heat related illness. It can develop in minutes.

Do this: No walks on hot pavement. Test it with the back of your hand. Fresh water always available. Never leave a dog in a parked car, even briefly.



Coco panting in the shade with a water bowl, sun overhead, heat-safety scene

Why Coco cares about number five

Coco is a French Bulldog. Flat faced breeds cannot cool themselves the way longer nosed dogs can, so heat is not a minor risk for her. It is the one I watch hardest.

THE POINT OF THIS SECTION

Four of these five cost very little to prevent and a great deal to treat. That gap is the single best return available to a dog owner.



4

Home Hazard Audit

Walk your house once with this. It takes about ten minutes.

Tick what is already handled. Anything left unticked is your list.

KITCHEN

- ☐ Medication in a closed cupboard
- ☐ Grapes and raisins out of reach
- ☐ Chocolate and sweets put away
- ☐ Bin has a secure lid
- ☐ Onions and garlic stored away

LIVING AREAS

- ☐ Cables tucked away or covered
- ☐ Small toys and remotes off the floor
- ☐ Houseplants checked for toxicity
- ☐ No string, ribbon or hair ties out
- ☐ Sofa gaps checked for lost items

BATHROOM

- ☐ Medicine cabinet closed properly
- ☐ Cleaning products stored high
- ☐ Toilet lid kept down
- ☐ No razors or floss within reach
- ☐ Bin covered or out of reach

OUTSIDE & GARAGE

- ☐ Antifreeze stored sealed and high
- ☐ Pesticides locked away
- ☐ Fence checked for gaps
- ☐ Toxic plants removed or raised
- ☐ Shade available in warm weather

ONE MORE THING WORTH DOING

Photograph the inside of your medicine and cleaning cupboards. If your dog ever gets into something, telling the vet exactly what and how much saves critical time.

TOXIC OR SAFE

Tick one box for each

Seven things people commonly have at home. Which are dangerous for a dog? Answer key on page 15.

ITEM	TOXIC	SAFE
Grapes and raisins	☐	☐
Plain cooked carrot	☐	☐
Dark chocolate	☐	☐
Blueberries	☐	☐
Onions and garlic	☐	☐
Xylitol in sugar-free gum	☐	☐
Macadamia nuts	☐	☐

5 Your Emergency Page

Fill this in today. Print it. Put it on the fridge.

This is the page that matters at 11pm. Filling it in takes five minutes and removes the worst part of an emergency, which is not knowing where to go.

ALWAYS AVAILABLE, 24 HOURS

ASPCA Animal Poison Control
(888) 426-4435

Pet Poison Helpline
(855) 764-7661

Both may charge a consultation fee. Both are staffed around the clock.

MY REGULAR VET

Practice name

Phone

Address

Opening hours

NEAREST 24 HOUR EMERGENCY CLINIC

Clinic name

Phone

Address

Drive time from home

ABOUT MY DOG

Name and age

Breed and weight

Ongoing conditions or medication

Microchip number

Insurance provider and policy number

Emergency contact if I am unreachable



6 Paying For It

A plain description of the options. Not a recommendation.

PLEASE READ THIS FIRST

We are not licensed to give financial or insurance advice, and this section does not do so. What follows is a neutral description of what exists so you can research and decide for yourself.

Pet insurance

You pay a monthly premium. Eligible costs are reimbursed after a deductible.

Terms vary widely. Pre-existing conditions are typically excluded, so cover becomes harder to obtain as a dog ages. Around a third of owners hold a policy.

A dedicated savings fund

You set money aside yourself, in a separate account, for veterinary costs.

No exclusions and no claims process. The limitation is that an emergency can arrive before the balance is meaningful.

Wellness or care plans

Monthly plans some practices offer covering routine care.

These usually cover planned care rather than emergencies. Check what is and is not included.

Clinic payment plans

Some practices will spread a large bill over an agreed period.

Availability varies by clinic and is often decided case by case. Worth asking about before you need it.

Third party financing

Lenders offering credit specifically for veterinary and medical costs.

Terms differ substantially. Some carry deferred interest that can be costly if not cleared within the promotional window. Read the terms closely.

Charitable assistance

Charities and breed specific funds that help owners in financial hardship.

Eligibility and available funds vary. Your vet may know which schemes operate locally.

Emergency Cheat Sheet

Print it. Screenshot it. Put it somewhere you will find it in a hurry.

GO NOW — do not wait to see if it settles

- Struggling to breathe
- Suspected poisoning
- Unproductive retching
- Bleeding that will not stop
- Collapse, cannot stand
- Pale, white or blue gums
- Repeated vomiting
- Suspected fracture
- Seizure
- Swollen, hard belly
- Unconscious
- Sudden vision loss

THE PREVENTABLE FIVE

Toxins — meds, grapes, chocolate
 Swallowed objects — socks, string
 Dental — brush 3x a week
 Weight — measure meals
 Heat — never a hot car or pavement

BEFORE YOU CALL, HAVE READY

What happened and when
 What they ate, and how much
 Your dog's weight and age
 Current medication
 Symptoms in order of appearance

POISON CONTROL, 24 HOURS

ASPCA (888) 426-4435

My vet: _____ 24hr clinic: _____

Pet Poison (855) 764-7661

WHILE YOU WAIT — DO NOT

- Induce vomiting unless told to
- Give human painkillers
- Offer food or water if collapsed
- Try to remove a stuck object
- Drive without calling ahead

ROUGH COST RANGES

Emergency exam \$150–500
 Poisoning \$300–3,000+
 Object surgery \$1,500–5,000
 Bloat surgery \$2,000–7,500
 Heat stroke \$500–2,500

THE ONE LINE TO REMEMBER

Calling early costs a phone call. Calling late can cost everything else.

You Are More Ready Than You Were

You now know what emergencies actually cost, how to tell a call-now situation from a watch-and-wait one, and which five expensive problems are largely preventable. If you filled in page 12, you also have the numbers you would need at 11pm.

That is genuinely more than most dog owners have.

THREE THINGS WORTH DOING THIS WEEK

Save both poison control numbers into your phone. Look up your nearest 24 hour clinic and note the drive time. Walk through the hazard audit on page 11 once, properly.

ANSWER KEY

No peeking until you have had a go

PAGE 4 — MATCH THE COST

Bloat = \$2,000 to \$7,500
Emergency exam only = \$150 to \$500
Toxin ingestion = \$300 to \$3,000+
Foreign object surgery = \$1,500 to \$5,000

PAGE 7 — TRIAGE DRILL

1. Now. Pale gums plus weakness.
2. Watch. Bright and eating is reassuring.
3. Now. Retching plus a hard belly.

PAGE 11 — TOXIC OR SAFE

Toxic: grapes and raisins, dark chocolate, onions and garlic, xylitol gum, macadamia nuts.
Safe in moderation: plain cooked carrot and blueberries.
Xylitol is the one owners miss most often.

THE COCO LIBRARY — the complete guide pack

Six guides covering dental health, flat-face care, apartment living, nutrition myths, puppy foundations and senior mobility. The prevention side, in more depth.

Available on the thank-you page after your download.

A closing note

Everything here is general guidance and cannot replace an examination. If something worries you, call your vet. That call is never the wrong decision.